from embarking on a nuclear arms race with India.[4] Reflecting on this episode two years later, S. Jaishankar, then India's Deputy Chief of Mission in Tokyo, observed that "our bilateral ties do not constitute an adequate counterweight to restrain Japan on an issue of significant concern" and that Japan's "language of demands, rewards and punishments, benchmarks and so on, is reflective of a donor syndrome at its worst."[5]

Fast forward to 14 September 2017. Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe, while laying the foundation stone of India's first bullet-train project to be built using a substantial soft loan from Japan and to be based on Japan's *Shinkansen* technology, said, "a strong India is in Japan's interest, and a strong Japan is in India's interest."[6] At the official summit meeting on the same day, he was reported to have said that "the Japan-India relationship is blessed with the largest potential for development of any bilateral relationship in the world."[7] Between these two events – India's nuclear tests and the inauguration of India's first bullet-train project – lies the story of an unprecedented warming of relations between Asia's two democratic major powers. The intervening two decades have seen the two countries engage in multiple high-level visits, annual Prime Ministerial summits, military exercises, strategic dialogues, thematic working groups, a comprehensive free-trade agreement, massive growth in bilateral trade and investment, and – to the surprise of many – an agreement on civilian nuclear cooperation that crucially did not place significant restrictions on India's use of spent fuel emanating from reactors imported from Japan and left open the question of cooperation in the event of a future Indian nuclear test.[8]

This chapter examines the drivers behind the remarkable upswing in India–Japan relations over the last two decades. It does so primarily from the Indian perspective, asking what factors have driven the India–Japan rapprochement.